

Placing Geographical Imagination in Film: New Zealand Filmmakers' Use of Landscape

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ABSTRACT

The paper explores the role of landscape in New Zealand films. How is the New Zealand landscape imagined and revealed? What kind of landscape do filmmakers present? I argue that New Zealand filmmakers tap into specific geographical imaginations when they make films, and that this results in certain kinds of landscapes being produced. I sketch the methodology used in a survey of New Zealand films and 'read' a selection of opening and closing sequences and 'generic places' found in a selection of contemporary New Zealand films. I then offer some conclusions about New Zealand films, and their production, portrayal and imagining of New Zealand.

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Introduction

The New Zealand film industry and New Zealand landscape are well recognised around the world thanks to the very popular *The Lord of the Rings* (Jackson, 1999/2000). This trilogy is part of a genre in which the New Zealand landscape is used to tell the stories of others. This paper, however, looks at how New Zealand filmmakers narrate *New Zealand* stories and places through landscape. These stories and their films dominate New Zealand filmmaking, and are worth prioritising as they offer a window into how New Zealanders understand and express relationships to their places.

The landscape that any filmmaker presents is complex, containing many layers of meaning, activity and construction. New Zealand filmmakers tap into a specific set of geographical imaginations, and this results in certain kinds of landscapes being produced in film. By exploring these dimensions, I draw some preliminary conclusions around the relationship between people and places, and how they imagine those places.

'Reading' the landscape is an acknowledged method of examining and interpreting landscape (Cosgrove and Daniels, 1988, Duncan and Duncan, 1988, Meinig, 1979). Movies provide an interesting challenge when using this methodology as they involve a different type of landscape to that usually examined. Film landscape is unique for several reasons. It is made up of thousands of still frames but appears to be moving. In this way it is both like a painting and similar to real life but matches neither. Since there are many agents involved in creating film landscape, investigating the processes by which film landscape is constructed, in order to 'read' it is both more rewarding and more involved. Film landscape is both a deliberate construct through the use of sets, trick photography and framing, and a 'real' representation through use of existing landscape (Kawin, 1992). Finally, film landscape is captured only once on film, yet is potentially indelible on the psyche as the unchanging landscape of a film is re-viewed by many on different occasions.

The uniqueness of film landscape necessitates a new approach to landscape interpretation. I adapt geography and

film studies theory to create a tool for analysis by drawing on Aitken and Zonn (1994), Lukinbeal (1995), Crang (1999), Gregory (1994, 2000a,b,c) and Mitchell (2000). I conceptualise film as a situated *layering of landscape*, that can be thickened by the addition of ideas, people and construction, and thinned as the result is reduced to a flat celluloid surface and geographical imaginations surrounding the landscape are limited to the version shown on film.

The paper explores the general question: how do New Zealand filmmakers place New Zealand and New Zealanders in films using geographical imagination? I tackle this with two perspectives, in order to explore the strategies filmmakers use to access the shared pool of ideas about people's reactions to places, landscapes, space and nature (Gregory, 2000a). The first perspective allows a look at how filmmakers set up expectations by placing us in the film in certain ways. In New Zealand the ambiguities and conflicts of Maori and Paheka culture and history have given rise to distinctive context. The second perspective takes the film as a whole; I explore how generic places (and their associated geographical imaginations of Aotearoa/New Zealand) are used to elicit reactions from an audience. Together these perspectives applied in New Zealand give a sense of both the role of landscape within a film and the geographic imaginations tapped into by filmmakers.

Opening and closing sequences are overtly place-making in intent and form. They provide a useful starting point for exploring geographical imaginations, because they are symptomatic of how places are treated in the film as a whole. Often known as 'establishing shots', they outline for the audience the nature of the films' setting. There is a relationship between the way establishing shots deal with material landscapes and the subsequent role of landscape in a film. As Watson (pers comm., 2001) observes "The opening sequence ... is where the director makes an overt statement about the setting and its symbolic significance".

Arguably, the New Zealand filmmaking industry began in 1977 and has retained its broad characteristics since this time (Le Héron (2002), Reid (1986), Martin and Edwards (1997)). Some 151 films were made between 1977 and 2001.¹ From this, a set of 34 illustrative films was identified on the basis of their iconic qualities and importance in the New Zealand scene. This set was then examined in terms of opening and closing sequences. Those investigated in depth were chosen because they were representative of key strategies and because interviews with directors and other information available about the films provided a broader basis for context and understanding. Interviews with 12 key subjects from the film industry (directors, cinematographers, actors, viewers, film academics) revealed insights into their techniques, philosophies and experiences of making and using landscapes in film, providing new interpretations when analysing their films.

In this paper film landscape is analysed in two ways. First, by a selective survey of establishing shot sequences since 1977. Second, by considering a selection of films in their entirety to gauge the use of generic place types within the

story. This approach helps answer the research question because it shows through examples how the practices of filmmaking enable viewers to link their common understandings of landscape to the story.

Opening and closing sequences

Establishing shots inform the viewer of the role that a place is expected to have in film. Such shots are more than technical exercises. They are constitutive of landscape, by constraining how it can be read and embedding hopes about how it might be read. New Zealand filmmakers utilise three main strategies to introduce their stories via landscape.

1. Landscape processes and forces are not important in the story
2. The land dominates relationships
3. The land dominates the action

Each gives scope for different treatment of landscape, and different interventions by directors. In the first, landscape sets the scene, but has little engagement with the audience or characters after this. The second and third strategies in contrast give precedence to the role of landscape in the lives of characters. Here the treatment of opening scenes (where this premise is set up) is quite different.

Landscape sets the scene

Where landscape is used simply as a placing mechanism, the introductory montage typically shows a great deal of information (landscape shots). Setting is easily established and revolves around generic place expectations. These are the only landscape-devoted shots in the film. Landscape does not play a large or direct role in the narrative, instead relationships are the feature of the story. 'Calendar' landscapes (Mune pers comm., 2001) or 'spectacle' landscapes (Conrich, 2001) common in the mid 1980s involved opening sequences panning around vast, empty, and still landscape of mountains, plains or rivers. The form is simple: very similar repetitive shots, which position New Zealand as an object to be gazed upon. More recently films which only desire to 'set the scene' have included some movement within the backdrop landscape to engage the viewer more fully.

Magik and Rose (Alexander, 1999) is conventional in introducing its characters and setting. The camera follows a vehicle as it drives around the headlands, across plains, to arrive in the town of Hokitika. As we watch a character approach the site of action and travel through the landscape we learn a little about that place. As this setting is not a nationally recognised place image, *Magik and Rose* relies on a sign to inform the viewer where they are. This is both helpful (Hokitika 'Wild Foods Capital' becomes an exotic destination) and unhelpful. Filmmakers, who do not have an automatic set of assumptions in which to locate their story and characters in the opening sequence, must do this work and pass on the key messages about the film: that a

stranger is arriving in a small town after having been on a journey.

In contrast, the opening sequence featuring the Auckland motorway in *Once Were Warriors* (Tamahori, 1994) immediately places the viewer in a fast-paced, urban, ghetto context. The film shows intertextuality between movies in its opening sequence. It begins with what appears to be the usual presentation of empty fields and mountains, but it turns into a billboard advertisement, with a tourist promotion style image, and then to the sound of harsh guitar chords that emphasise the twang of disillusionment, the camera pulls back to reveal gritty urban streets. *Once Were Warriors* consciously parodies the 'calendar' style representation of New Zealand once common in New Zealand films.

Jubilee's (Hurst, 1999) opening montage introduces a 'typical' small town as the site for action. The montage features mostly peopleless and static shots of a very small community. Iconographic images of New Zealand are used - a rugby field and a giant kumara (sweet potato) place Waimatua in the ranks of very small New Zealand towns attempting to draw attention to themselves with an eye-catching structure. Director Hurst (pers comm. 2001) vocalised his search for somewhere that would fit his conception of small town New Zealand and the type of place in which his story should unfold. This emphasises the relationship that exists between people, their presumed construction of place-based relationships and their expectations of places. Indeed, such is the emphasis on setting the scene, that it is almost as though the story of *Jubilee* cannot be properly told unless the viewers are firmly situated in Waimatua and educated as to the type of place it is. Place implicitly ascribes particular relationships.

Ngati (Barclay, 1986), the first film to be made by a Maori writer/director, does not altogether conform to classic opening sequences. Indeed, Barclay claims in his book *Our Own Image* (1990) that Maori have a different cultural framework, and thus have different methods, processes and results, when making a film (as for other things). *Ngati* begins with an opening setup shot, but unlike many New Zealand films, the very first image is not of landscape location, but of people. A tohunga (religious elder) gravely enters a house - no explanation is given at this stage to those unfamiliar with cultural practices. The second shot shows a bus wending its way down a hill to the bay below (the presumed location of the kaumatua (elder) seen just before). *Ngati's* closing scene mirrors this beginning almost exactly. The bus leaves, and we can see the bay (location of all incidents in the film) in the background, as it draws away. Then the film cuts to the young boy in the midst of the people of his community. People to land to people.² *Ngati* offers a strong sense of place through its setup in the opening scenes.

Perhaps Barclay's privileging of people over landscape was noted and adopted by others in the industry. Or perhaps, recent New Zealand movies reflect a general move from 'calendar' beginnings, to more engaging ones. In any event, film beginnings have diversified. Backdrop type openings

feature less often as the first shots. Increasingly, initial scenes involving people precede landscape sequences.

Landscape dominates relationships

To inform viewers that landscape will have an influential role in *relationships* throughout the film, filmmakers often show landscape first, directly followed by shots of people.

The Price of Milk (Sinclair, 1999) begins by placing the viewer in a pastoral paradise. This setting is crucial to the way the couple's marital conflict is worked out. Its opening scenes are almost motionless. It is early morning, very green and only the cattle are awake. Having established the potential isolation and peace of the valley, Sinclair's next shot foreshadows conflict as a quilt is dragged off a bed. Only then do we meet the characters. *The Price of Milk's* beginning initially appears to fall back into the mode of presenting beautiful but uninformative landscape ('here is the beautiful landscape we are in' mode). However, it progresses from this in several important respects. While the first few minutes of the film contain only unpeopled landscape, it is not presented in a panoramic sweep of the area. Instead, abbreviated glimpses are offered as a series of snapshots. This captures attention as the viewer feels there is intention behind the images. Sinclair thus highlights the importance of grass-covered hillsides to his forthcoming story and discloses the personal conflict of the (sleeping) couple.

Landscape dominates action

Films where landscape dominates the action usually begin showing people and *then* landscapes. This order is significant. It allows filmmakers to introduce characters who are then set in an environment that influences all subsequent *actions*. Landscape is *where* the main action occurs. In these films, the landscape featured is grand, majestic and overwhelming. The landscape is an active participant in the film and has a direct bearing on characters' actions. In these films generic place expectations are used and treated as more than thematic settings - they are integral to the narrative.

Illustrious Energy (Narbey, 1987) manifests its relationship between people and the environment by beginning with a shot of a large white cloud in a deep blue sky. The ranges are golden brown, backed by blue sky. Our first introduction to people shows them only partially, as hands dig up bare earth, tussock and rock to access a grave. The land is of such significance in their daily lives that its influence continues until death. The two men uncover a friend who did not return to China before the land claimed him. The sky, clear light and sense of immense space dominate the opening shots of *Illustrious Energy*. The protagonists' attention is often on the heavens and increases the sense of openness felt by the viewer. It is at once an attractive yet lonely land, with its qualities of intense sky and continuous rolling hills bereft of inhabitants. Significantly, when people are shown in the landscape, they appear small against the dominating empty hills and at the mercy of the elements. But sense of place is

such a central part of this film, that the sequence which establishes the land as a presence is justified. These choices of framing establish the Central Otago hills as meaningful aspects of the narrative. The goldpanners' lives are tied up in what the hills offer them: a bright horizon and gold in the ground.

As if energised by the title, soundscape forms part of the landscape of *Illustrious Energy*. Chirping crickets, clucking chickens and the rushing river enhance the hard Otago land. Words are only additions to the story being told by the place in which the characters live. This film could not have been shot elsewhere and retain its sense of self, and of realism. Filmed on location in Central Otago, *Illustrious Energy* captures the clear light and barren openness that New Zealanders often glorify in representations of the area. The land is a protagonist, influencing other characters' lives through weather, the offer of gold and its own immensity (see Le Héron, 2002 for further exploration of the role of landscape as agency in films).

Illustrious Energy subscribes to the trend of beginning and ending a film in a similar setting as the character Chan walks towards town across tussocky ranges overshadowed by the magnificent hills. This technique frequently rounds off a tale, and is thus a useful storytelling device. From a visual perspective, repetitive use of situations at formative opening and closing moments emphasises their importance to the entire film.

The Piano (Campion, 1992) also follows the trend of neatly finishing as it began. In this case, the beginning and the end have two parts to each of them. Campion introduces Ada (and Ada's story) from her perspective. We see as if through her eyes, as she peeks through her interlaced fingers at the world around her. This world is Victorian England, a grey silent place. After a few shots that allow for sufficient voice-over narration to outline Ada's situation, we cut abruptly to her arrival in New Zealand. The angular hull of a boat cuts through water above the camera in a bright blue image that directly contrasts with the sombreness of previous scenes. The movie's end forms the closing bracket to the narrative. Once again, Ada travels by water with her piano. Again, the camera presents a view from below the surface. We see Ada fall down through clear water to her potential grave. A voice-over begins to summarise her experiences and continues to explain the epilogue as we see her in Nelson. The last scene finds Ada once more in civilisation, though a far brighter one than we were shown at the start of the movie. She walks around the balcony of a large colonial house, and plays her piano, much as she walked and played in England. At times a romantic and violent tale, *The Piano*'s arduous setting of colonial bush clearing New Zealand is confined to the central narrative of the film. It is almost as if Ada's experience was a nightmare and the community in the bush a nightmarish place she was happy to leave. The bush is the only place violence and disruption occur – it is a place of awe and horror, a fitting setting for such behaviour, and inappropriate for attempted refinement. But Ada wears the scars of this violence on her hand in the closing scene. The structure of the opening sequences

immediately informs us that colonial New Zealand is a place of bright futures in contrast to England. However, immediately following this information (in the form of a bright shot of a boat through water) the 'brave new world' is shown as a wild deserted beach. Ada eventually finds salvation and redemption, but not at her initial landing place. Thus the establishing shots signal Campion's intentions about the setting.

The three strategies outlined reveal links between the ways New Zealand films represent aspects of New Zealand landscape and the techniques filmmakers use to accomplish their tasks. New Zealand film appears to adopt and play with some conventions about portraying New Zealand. Decisions about opening scenes are largely determined by the key people-landscape relationship that the narrative explores. Having established the importance of landscape in opening sequences of films I turn now to the creative construction of particular landscapes in New Zealand film. These landscapes are constituted as generic places, by accessing New Zealand geographical imaginations and through the use of filmic tropes.

Generic places in film landscapes

Film constructs geographies (and landscapes) that rely on and interact with people's knowledge of geographies they live in. New Zealand filmmakers adopt stereotypical representations of human-environment relationships. There is an interesting link between New Zealanders' experience of places and the portrayal of those places in film – generally commonly experienced landscapes receive little attention, while landscapes embodied with emotion and a tradition of representation continue to be denoted in familiar ways. Emotions and behaviours commonly associated with these places are reinforced, as they are repeatedly represented.

Symbolic landscapes, once the focus for attention, become available for new or derived symbolic purposes. Old meanings contribute to and add to any new meanings (Davies, 1988). New ideas are often explored through existing symbols or metaphors, but equally, old ideas gain currency through repetition. Thus, generic places portrayed in New Zealand film combine historical associations with new interpretations.

Generic places can take many forms. In this section I focus on pasture or countryside, the bush, rivers, mountains, beaches and cities. In spite of such easy identification and categorisation, generic places can be used in a variety of ways, as vehicles for a spectrum of emotions and ironies which infuse the social relations of place.

Pasture and countryside

The countryside is one the most commonly experienced 'type of place' (outside cities) in New Zealand. However, as Sinclair recognised (pers comm., 2001), it is seldom represented in New Zealand film. Unlike 'the bush' which holds recognised historical and cultural significance, New Zealand's countryside is a result of bush clearing and

economic strategies. Failure to represent them as significant elements of New Zealand landscape partially erases processes of clearing and farming, by ignoring the cleared and farmed land. Or is it merely that the commonness of paddocks renders them boring? They are not romantic, whereas bush is full of enticing references and stories.

Successful filmmakers play with ideas surrounding generic places. Sinclair challenges notions of pasture and countryside in his film *The Price of Milk*. This film contradicts expectations by combining romantic love and a working farm environment. Sinclair consciously tries to re-image New Zealand farmland as a dreamy location. The film is about "reinventing New Zealand as a romantic place" (Sinclair pers comm., 2001). Love and pasture are not commonly associated, so the film introduces a set of emotions that are very definitely 'out of place' (Cresswell, 1996). One of the reasons that *The Price of Milk* defies expectations is because of the way landscape is worked. Once a viewer accepts the unlikely combination of farming and romanticism, happy dreamlike times are expected in the fairytale landscape. They do not always occur, but it is significant that in refuting generic place expectations, Sinclair creates a specific twist on them for his film.

'The bush'

New Zealand's stories regularly incorporate 'the bush' and its emotional resonance. It is filmed far more frequently than its percentage of land cover would suggest necessary. I attribute this to its emotional history that is tied up with notions of being a New Zealander. Film (and other) narratives frequently forge new stories in attempts to forget defeat in the bush. The bush fits more neatly into Pakeha ideas about nature being alive than mountains or tamed paddocks. Films also symbolically tame the land (bush), an ongoing Pakeha project. However, the bush is not a single or homogenous place and is represented differently both between films and within them.

Utu (Murphy, 1982) provides some different interpretations on the usual portrayal of bush landscape. Most significantly, the bush in *Utu* is inhabited. All other film representations show bush as an empty place that characters traverse or visit, rather than a lived-in place. It is also a place of mist and mystery where British troops get lost and Maori escape to the bush to hide. This idea of bush as refuge is not a new one and is taken up in a variety of other New Zealand films. In *Goodbye Pork Pie* (Murphy, 1980) the main characters hide from cops. In *Sleeping Dogs* (Donaldson, 1977) the protagonists hide from the army. In literature (Mulgan's *Man Alone*) the bush is a sanctuary.

While *Utu* draws upon strong resonances of bush as a sanctuary it also goes beyond this. The bush separates Maori and Pakeha communities, and for the rebel leader Te Wheke is also his home. We know from the initial scenes that British soldiers are not at ease in the bush – they are alienated and lost in the dense vegetation. In contrast, Maori are shown at home in the bush and free to dart

through the forests to wage war. These contrasts match with general cultural assumptions about the bush. Maori conceptualise the forest as a place of life (Tanemahuta presides over the forest and all its creatures), whereas European history links forest with death (Schama, 1995). *Utu* thus contrasts Maori and Pakeha identities and the bush.

A young Maori actor interviewed in *Making Utu* (Preston, 1982) stated his opinion of the film battles, the bush and a character's place amongst them. He perceived the bush as 'our ground' (Maori) and the settlement Te Puna as 'their ground' (Pakeha). Clearly, his conceptualisation of the bush belonging to Maori and pasture to Pakeha are racial categories. *Utu* too, works along these lines, despite the attempt at blurring racial divisions in other ways (e.g. dialogue and moral decisions). The grounding of character types in their proper places makes a strong statement about where people belong, and how much symbolism is unconsciously associated with bush. In this, *Utu* attempts to challenge categories, but is not radical enough. Ultimately, it perpetuates stereotypes.

Director Campion recognised the strength of automatic New Zealand associations with the bush. She subsequently sought a specific quality of bush for her film *The Piano* to tap into these emotions.

The bush has got an enchanted, complex, even frightening quality to it, unlike anything that you see anywhere else. It's mossy and very intimate, and there's an underwater look that's always charmed me. I was after the vivid, *subconscious imagery* of the bush, its dark, inner world (Bilborough, 1992:139, my emphasis).

The two films, *Utu* and *The Piano*, incorporate the bush into their storylines extensively and deal simultaneously with some aspect of emerging national identity in a colonial context. In this period, native forest was a dominating force psychologically (our continuing fascination with the bush is one of the repercussions of that era). Pakeha settlers saw the bush for its potential value rather than as an existing resource. They wanted to transform land into productive pasture. Both *Utu* and *The Piano* use this value system of transformation for progress as an underlying theme.

Rivers, mountains and beaches

Rivers are not dominant features in films, though they run through much of New Zealand. Nor are they incorporated with sufficient frequency to make sweeping conclusions about their role. Nevertheless, the examples I examined, give enough evidence to conclude that rivers (when present) play quietly important situating roles. Narrative turning points often occur at rivers.

The ubiquitous small river gets many cameo parts in New Zealand film, while more imposing mountains and ranges, that are the physical backbone of New Zealand, rarely feature. In terms of cultural significance, mountains loom large in both Pakeha and Maori traditions. Mountains traditionally symbolise the unachievable and awe-inspiring nature for Europeans and Maori stories personify mountains.

Mountains are also commonly part of projected images of New Zealand both in the country and sent overseas (Pawson, 2002). Many New Zealanders have experience of mountain activities (skiing, climbing, tramping), as they become increasingly popular pastimes. All these circumstances make it puzzling that mountains are under-represented in New Zealand film. *The Lord of the Rings* uses spectacular mountain backdrops to achieve both a sense of scale, a sense of awe, and as part of the storyline - but not as New Zealand. Pakeha stories about climbing mountains are more likely to be set in Nepal (or Middle Earth) than in New Zealand. None of the films I examined incorporated mountains either as backdrops or as more integral parts of the story that recognise their symbolic value. In New Zealand narratives, we cannot conquer the land (though bush stories continuously attempt to do so). Ever-present economic factors may restrict filming in potentially extreme, distant and dangerous environments, but I suspect it is more a reluctance to engage with challenges to New Zealand metanarratives that delivers mountain-free landscapes to our screens.

Beaches form part of traditional summer experiences, and as such, receive as much emotional commitment from New Zealanders as bush landscape generates. Curiously then, beaches seldom appear in film. *The End of the Golden Weather* (Mune, 1991) explicitly locates itself on the beach. In this film based on childhood memories (and Bruce Mason's play), the beach is a site of fantasy and potential for an adolescent boy. In *The Piano* however, the beach represents an uncertain future for Ada in an untamed new world. Both these films draw on the discourse of beaches as liminal places. They manifest the insecurity of characters and are places where unusual behaviour is accepted. Ngati also situates some action on the beach, though not the majority of the drama. In this case, the beach is presented as a community locale. This offers a different interpretation of beach space: rather than providing ambiguity, the beach suggests belonging.

Cities

Urban settlements appear in New Zealand films, but usually films that set themselves in this context feature suburbia or small towns. *Once Were Warriors*, though nominally (and initially) set in a large city, situates most of its action in a rundown suburban area. New Zealanders are not traditionally proud of cities. Perhaps this explains the lack of engagement with 'the big city'. *Stickmen* (Rothwell, 2000) and *Topless Women Talk About Their Lives* (Sinclair, 1997) partially capture the rhythm of large cities, but do not portray nightlife that American films base their accounts of cities around.

When action is based in small towns or suburbia (the residual categories into which most New Zealand films locate), indoor scenes predominate. They are cheap to film, but so are New Zealand landscapes. However, New Zealand film drama usually focuses on tense scenes of interpersonal interaction, rather than action movies. Concentrating the

camera on people as the main characters, alleviates the need for careful construction of landscape.

Travel between spaces

Mobility is a feature of New Zealand life. We commute within the city, we travel out of the city for holidays, and out of the country for our OE.³ New Zealand filmmakers explore mobility. Road movies such as *Snakeskin* (Ashurst, 2000) and *Goodbye Pork Pie* follow characters' journeys around New Zealand. They move between spaces, often for a definite purpose, though they do not always achieve it. Characters in film thus move from space to space, between wild, semi-tame and tame places, in search of an appropriate site for current action. By continually reframing and juxtaposing shots, filmmakers change expected emotions, elements and characters.

Conclusions about reading film landscapes

It is apparent that New Zealand film appears to play with some conventions about portraying New Zealand. However, filmmakers generally reinforce stereotypes about New Zealanders and their relationship with land. In films where place plays a backseat role, opening (and closing) sequences only set the scene. They give the viewer the information needed to understand the narrative. In contrast, in films that attribute a large role to landscape, the introductory scenes introduce characters. Place information does not need to be outlined up front because it is expanded on throughout the film. Further, the generic places of Aotearoa/New Zealand elicited through my analysis suggest a strong relationship between geographical imaginations and film. Connotations are regularly drawn upon by filmmakers, and in the process become more acceptable and obvious choices for the next similar film.

New Zealand filmmakers appear to be very aware of these conventions, utilise them fully and to their full extent.⁴ At times, filmmakers challenge place expectations, but contest them in ways that do not break free from strong place-bound associations. This can be attributed both to the strength of these links and the suitability of film as a medium to express them. Film, as a European way of seeing, easily interprets Pakeha geographical imaginations to the screen, using a relatively narrow selection of framings and symbols.

European framings dominate film internationally. Pakeha images and imaginations dominate New Zealand film. This logical link occurs because most films are made by Pakeha in a European medium. Place ideas are framed well by these selected setups. New Zealand Pakeha geographical imaginations fit easily into the framework and are used (relatively) unproblematically by filmmakers. Even when such framings are questioned, the challenge occurs from within, rather than by ignoring compositional framing modes altogether.

Place construction in films is demonstrably complex and the use of landscape quite variable. Although filmmakers' individual visions influence the contribution landscape

makes, landscape is important in *all* films, regardless of whether landscape dominates or not. Understandings of generic places cannot be erased simply because a film does not obviously present them. Instead, assumptions based on shared geographic imaginations are drawn upon. Films that feature landscape explicitly reference these ideas, films that

use landscape in a background manner *implicitly* employ them. Film displays shared assessments of places. Such perceptions manifest in all films as *idealised places* (or echoes of them). Film landscape is thus elaborate and many layered. This analysis reveals that the work landscape does in film is much more complex than might have previously been considered.

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Notes

¹ The research for this paper was completed in 2001.

² Two Maori proverbs capture these priorities: He aha te mea nui? He tangata, he tangata, he tangata. (What is the most important thing? It is people, people, people); Whata ngarongaro he tangata, toitu he whenua (People disappear, but the land remains).

³ OE (Overseas Experience) is a common New Zealand term for travelling abroad.

⁴ One-to-one interviews with filmmakers in 2001 confirmed their awareness of these issues.

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Filmography

Goodbye Pork Pie 1980: Director Roger Donaldson.
Illustrious Energy 1987: Director Leon Narbey.
Jubilee 1999: Director Michael Hurst
Magik and Rose 1999: Director Vanessa Alexander
Making Utu 1982: Director/Producer Gaylene Preston.
Ngati 1986: Director Barry Barclay
Once Were Warriors 1994: Director Lee Tamahori
Sleeping Dogs 1977: Director Roger Donaldson

Snakeskin 2000: Director Gillian Ashurst
Stickmen 2000: Director Hamish Rothwell
The End of the Golden Weather 1991: Director Ian Mune
The Lord of the Rings (Trilogy) 1999/2000: Director Peter Jackson
The Piano 1992: Director Jane Campion
The Price of Milk 1999: Director Harry Sinclair
Topless Women Talk About Their Lives 1997: Director Harry Sinclair
Utu 1982: Director Geoff Murphy